

The \$60 Week

Seven dinners, one shopping trip, about sixty dollars. Built for two adults, with leftovers pulling half the weight.

I didn't design this week in a spreadsheet lab. Money got tight one spring, I gave myself \$60, and I figured I'd be living on instant noodles until things turned around. Instead I ended up eating better than I had in years, because a tight budget pushes you straight toward the foods that win on actual nutrition math.

Every price in here is real. We ranked 49 foods by protein per dollar and 53 by fiber per dollar, USDA nutrition data matched to July 2026 store prices, and this plan is built out of the winners. The whole thing runs on a \$25 backbone from the dry goods aisle. The other \$35 just fills in around it.

How to use this thing

- **Shop once.** The list on page 2 covers the whole week. Every extra "quick stop for milk" comes home with four things you didn't plan for.
- **Sunday is the whole game.** One two-hour batch session covers three days of dinners. Page 5 gives you the exact order so nothing waits on anything else.
- **Feeding more than two?** The system scales. Our guide to [stretching meals for bigger tables](#) covers the honorable ways to make eight servings out of six.
- **Your store isn't my store.** Prices will wobble a little by region, so the list carries about \$10 of built-in slack.
- **Underlined meals link to full recipes** on daily-life-hacks.com. The rest are simple enough to wing.

Print it, stick it on the fridge, and let the least photogenic aisle in the store carry the budget.

The One-Trip List / About \$60

Two lists. The backbone is the \$25 that does most of the actual feeding. The fill-ins buy produce, flavor, and flexibility. Check your pantry first: if you already own rice and oats, you're starting the week ahead.

THE \$25 BACKBONE	WHAT IT DELIVERS	PRICE
Pinto beans, 4 lb bag	Around 389 grams of protein, plus serious fiber	\$3.97
Green split peas, 16 oz bag	About 101 grams of fiber and a week of soup lunches	\$1.42
Chicken drumsticks, 5 lb bag	The meat counter's best bargain at \$1.09 per lb	\$5.45
Eggs, two dozen	The easiest protein in the kitchen, zero prep drama	\$4.40
Whole milk, 1 gallon	123 grams of protein hiding in the fridge door	\$4.22
Oats, rice, and whole wheat spaghetti	Every breakfast and dinner base for the week	~\$6.00
Backbone subtotal		~\$25

THE FILL-INS	WHY IT'S HERE	PRICE
Bananas, 3 lb	Breakfast sidekick at 65 cents a pound	\$1.95
Green cabbage, one head (about 3 lb)	The vegetable that refuses to go bad on you	\$2.34
Carrots, 2 lb bag	Soup, slaw, and snack duty all week	\$1.58
Yellow onions, 3 lb	The start of every pot on page 5	\$3.27
Frozen green peas, 32 oz bag	Nearly 3x the fiber per dollar of fresh broccoli	\$2.32
Frozen green beans, 32 oz bag	The backup vegetable that doesn't judge you	\$2.18
100% whole wheat bread, 20 oz loaf	For dragging through Monday's soup	\$1.97
Peanut butter, 40 oz jar	50 grams of protein per dollar, no cooking required	\$4.97
Mozzarella, 16 oz block	Makes pasta night feel like a decision, not a compromise	\$3.58
Fill-in subtotal		~\$24

That's about \$49.50 at the register. The last \$10 or so covers canned tomatoes for pasta and chili night, any spice gaps, and regional price differences. Come in under budget? Congratulations, that's next week's head start, not an invitation to the snack aisle. **Grand total: about \$60.**

The Seven Dinners, Part One / Sunday to Wednesday

Per-meal costs below use the same store prices as the shopping list. They're honest estimates, not lab results. Close enough is the whole philosophy here.

SUNDAY / BATCH DAY

~\$6 cooked, 3 days covered

Roasted drumsticks, with the week cooking itself alongside

Drumsticks roast in the oven while a pot of beans, a pot of rice, and the split pea soup simmer nearby. About \$6 of ingredients on the stove, and three days of dinners come off the line at once. The exact order of operations is on page 5, so nothing burns while you're stirring something else.

MONDAY

~\$3 the whole pot

Split pea soup with bread

The slow cooker did the work yesterday. Tonight you ladle and toast. The whole pot costs about \$3 and feeds you twice, which makes tomorrow's lunch a solved problem before you've eaten dinner.

TUESDAY

~\$2.50 for two plates

Beans and rice

The classic pairing where the legume and the grain cover each other's amino acid gaps. Dress it up with whatever the produce drawer offers. Roughly \$2.50 for two plates, and it keeps you full without a motivational speech. Make extra rice on purpose; Thursday depends on it.

WEDNESDAY

~\$4

One pot chicken and rice with frozen peas

Drumstick-friendly, one pan to wash, and it reheats better than it has any right to. This is the midweek meal that keeps the whole system from collapsing into takeout, which is exactly its job.

The Seven Dinners, Part Two / Thursday to Saturday

THURSDAY

Nearly free

Fried rice from Tuesday's extra rice, an egg on top

Leftovers, on purpose. Day-two rice fries properly instead of steaming into mush, which makes Thursday the night your planning pays out. More ways to put old rice to work in our [leftover rice guide](#).

FRIDAY

~\$3.50

Pasta night

Whole wheat spaghetti, canned tomatoes, and whatever vegetables need using. About \$3.50, and it clears the produce drawer before anything turns into compost with a receipt attached. Grate some of that mozzarella over the top. You earned it, it's Friday.

SATURDAY

The flex night

Beans become [chili](#), or the freezer offers something up

This is also where the leftover drumsticks land. If the week went sideways somewhere, Saturday absorbs it. That's not a flaw in the plan; that's the plan having shock absorbers.

Wait, what about breakfast and lunch?

- **Breakfasts are oats or eggs all week**, maybe \$1 a day for two people. Oatmeal with a sliced banana, scrambled eggs and toast, rotate as needed. Nobody's winning a brunch award here, but nobody's hungry at 10 AM either.
- **Lunches are last night's dinner**, which is why every dinner on these two pages makes extra on purpose. The soup, the beans and rice, and the chicken all reheat without complaint.
- **The peanut butter, bananas, and milk** exist for exactly the hours between meals. That's the snack budget, and it works harder than most snack budgets.

Notice what's missing from this week: coupons, suffering, and any meal that's just rice with sadness.

Sunday Batch Day / The Exact Order

Here's the honest catch with budget staples: a bag of dried beans costs 22 cents per 100 grams and is also completely inedible at 6 PM on a Tuesday. Two hours on Sunday fixes that for the whole week. This is the order that wastes zero minutes.

- 1 Saturday night: soak the pintos.** A bowl, water, done. Forgot? The [same-day quick soak](#) kills that excuse in about an hour.
- 2 Sunday, first move: split peas into the slow cooker.** Peas, an onion, carrots, water. No soaking needed, no supervision wanted. That's Monday's dinner and two lunches cooking themselves while you do everything else. More hands-off ideas in our [cheap crockpot meals](#) roundup.
- 3 Pintos onto the back burner.** Drained, covered with fresh water, and left to simmer. They need the most time, so they start early. The full method is in [cooking dried beans from scratch](#), and it's easier than its reputation.
- 4 Big pot of rice.** Cook more than tonight needs; Tuesday and Thursday are counting on it. Cool it fast and store it right, because [how you store cooked grains](#) is the difference between fried rice and regret.
- 5 Drumsticks in the oven.** Tonight's dinner roasts while the pots simmer. Cook the whole 5 lb bag; the extras are already booked for Saturday.
- 6 Portion everything before you sit down.** Beans and rice into containers, soup into jars. Anything you won't touch by Wednesday goes straight to the freezer, where it waits for you instead of expiring at you.

Two hours, one cleanup, and the hardest cooking of the week is behind you. Every weeknight after this is assembly, not cooking, and that's the entire trick. If you want the full weekly method, [batch cooking for beginners](#) walks through it start to finish.

Swap Anything / By the Numbers

Store's out of drumsticks? Can't face another pinto? Swap by protein per dollar, not by vibes. Every number below comes from our 49-food study: USDA nutrition data matched to real July 2026 prices.

SWAP THIS FOR THAT	PROTEIN G PER \$1	PRICE
Pinto beans, dry (97.9 g per \$1)		
Black beans, dry	81.0	\$2.42 / 2 lb bag
Brown lentils, dry	77.7	\$1.44 / 16 oz bag
Navy beans, dry	75.9	\$2.67 / 2 lb bag
Green split peas, dry (73.9 g per \$1)		
Brown lentils, dry	77.7	\$1.44 / 16 oz bag
Red lentils, dry	56.0	\$1.94 / 16 oz bag
Chicken drumsticks (50.3 g per \$1)		
Chicken thighs, boneless skinless	27.7	\$3.22 / lb
Rotisserie chicken, whole	26.7	\$5.97 / bird
Whole chicken, raw	25.3	\$2.04 / lb
Eggs (34.4 g per \$1)		
Greek yogurt, plain nonfat	27.5	\$3.36 / 32 oz tub
Cottage cheese, 4%	26.3	\$2.87 / 24 oz tub
Canned tuna, chunk light	22.4	\$0.98 / 5 oz can
No time for dried beans this week?		
Canned black beans	30.1	\$0.88 / 15.5 oz can
Canned kidney beans	23.4	\$0.98 / 15.5 oz can

Notice the pattern: every drumstick swap costs you protein per dollar, which is exactly why drumsticks anchor the plan. The canned bean tax is real too, 30 grams per dollar versus 98 dry, but canned still beats every ground meat in the store. The swaps to skip: ground beef 80/20 delivers 11.5 grams per dollar and bacon delivers 9.2. At those numbers they're not proteins, they're flavorings with confidence.

That's the week. The full system behind it, the shopping habits, the batch cooking method, and both complete datasets live in the [Eat Healthy on a Budget playbook](http://www.daily-life-hacks.com) at www.daily-life-hacks.com. The beans will be there when you get back.